# Violet in the Dark
## By Massimo Musa

In the evening, Alison closes the shutters before the sun sets. She cannot bear to watch the light die on the walls, slide along the furniture, abandon the corners of the house. She turns on all the lamps, even those in the empty rooms, and waits for morning to come.

Darkness has a voice. It creaks in the wood of the furniture, groans in the pipes, creeps beneath the doors with the wind. Sometimes Alison turns on the television just to hear someone speak. Then night comes, the longest one, when even sleep seems to have forgotten the way home.

During her sleepless hours, she paints. She has set up her easel in the brightest room, in front of a large east-facing window. Canvases full of colour lean against the walls. She never paints the night. Even the shadows in her paintings have something transparent about them, as though light must always find a way through.

Behind the house is a small garden, squeezed between stone walls and trees that are too tall. The sun enters at an angle and soon disappears beyond the wall. In winter, damp covers the stones with moss and the leaves slowly rot, returning to the earth the scent of seasons past.

It is there that Alison finds the violet.

It grows in the crack between two stones, tiny, with five petals of a deep violet. Its slender stem bends beneath the weight of the flower, yet does not break. Around it, only moss, dark earth and a few exposed roots.

It seems to her that someone has forgotten a fragment of spring in that corner of winter. She would like to move it into a pot, near the kitchen window, but its roots wind between the stones. She tries to loosen them, then stops.

She leaves the violet where it is.

The following morning, she brings the easel near the kitchen window. She prepares her colours and begins to paint. She reproduces the wall, the moss, the damp stones. She mixes blue with red, adds a touch of white and searches for the violet of the petals. But when she applies the colour to the canvas, the flower seems to sink into the shadows. Its outlines blend with the stones and that violet, so intense in reality, becomes a dark patch, almost invisible.

Alison adds some white.

The flower reappears, but it is no longer the same.

She tries to lighten the wall, then the earth. Every brushstroke brings a little light, but takes something away from the garden. When she steps back from the easel, the violet seems to be growing in a different place, a brighter one, which she has never seen.

She wipes the flower away with a rag.

She starts again the following day. And the day after that. The canvases pile up against the wall. In some, the violet is too pale, in others, it almost disappears completely.

Meanwhile, in the garden, it continues to bloom between the stones.

Alison begins to visit it every morning. Sometimes she brings it water, other times she simply observes its petals. After the rain, tiny drops remain suspended on the leaves, tremble for an instant and fall into the moss.

One evening, she stays in front of the easel longer than usual. She has painted the wall in a shade of deep grey, letting the shadows of the trees descend all the way to the earth. The violet is there, almost swallowed by the painting.

She takes a clean brush, dips it in white and brings it towards the canvas.

She stops.

Through the window, the garden is immersed in twilight. The stones lose their outlines and the flower can no longer be distinguished.

She puts down the brush.

That evening, she eats dinner, often turning towards the windowpane. Before going to bed, she looks once more at the spot where the violet grows, now indistinguishable from the rest of the garden.

The following evening, she remains in front of the window until the sky loses even its last shade of blue.

One night, the wind comes from the sea. It bends the branches, makes the windowpanes vibrate. Alison wakes with a start. In the garden, something is striking against the wall.

She turns on the light and goes to the kitchen.

A branch has broken off and fallen into the corner where the violet grows.

She could wait until morning. After all, a flower is just a flower.

She goes back to bed, but every gust drags the branch against the stones. She turns onto one side, then the other. Finally, she throws back the covers.

She puts her coat over her nightdress, slips on her shoes and takes a torch.

She opens the door.

The night smells of wet earth. The wind lifts her hair and drives the cold against her face. She remains on the threshold, one hand gripping the door handle, the other wrapped around the torch.

She goes down the first step.

Then the second.

The light trembles across the ground, illuminating tufts of grass and stones glistening with rain. Alison reaches the broken branch and bends down to grasp it. It is heavy, swollen with water. She has to drag it with both hands, scratching a wrist against the bark.

The torch slips from her grasp.

It rolls over the stones and goes out.

Alison holds her breath.

The wind continues to pass through the trees. A drop slides down her neck. Somewhere beyond the wall, a dog barks twice.

She remains motionless, her hands dirty with earth.

Then she stretches out an arm.

Her fingers meet the cold moss, follow the crack between the stones and find the violet's leaves. She brushes them one by one, until she recognises the stem bent beneath the twigs. She gently frees it.

A petal remains stuck to her fingertip.

She brings it close to her face, but cannot make out its colour.

She remains crouching, listening to the wind.

Above the wall, between the branches, a small patch of sky opens up. A few stars appear and disappear behind the clouds.

When she stands up, her legs are numb. She retrieves the torch and heads back towards the house. Before going inside, she stops to look at the garden, immersed in the night.

She closes the door without turning on the hallway light.

The following morning, she finds the violet bent, with one petal missing. She removes the fallen leaves and straightens the stem slightly.

Then she enters the room where she paints.

The last canvas is still on the easel. The dark wall, the damp stones, the moss. In the centre, almost indistinguishable, the little violet.

Alison picks up the brush again. She searches for the violet of the petals, but the colour is once again lost among the stones.

She reaches for the white.

She hesitates.

Then she adds a small amount.

The flower reappears, pale, alien to the earth surrounding it.

She tries to darken the petals, then to lighten the stones. She works until the light begins to withdraw from the window. Finally, she lets the brush fall into the jar of water.

For two days, she does not paint.

One evening, while preparing dinner, she notices that the reflection of the lamp fills the window. She turns off the kitchen light and remains looking outside.

At first, she can distinguish only the blackness of the trees. Then the wall, the lighter stones, a thin strip of sky. The garden slowly regains its shapes.

The violet cannot be seen.

Alison remains for a few more moments, then returns to the stove.

That night, she falls asleep on the sofa without turning on the television. She wakes when the house is completely dark. She searches for the light switch, finds it, but before pressing it, she listens to the ticking of the clock and the groaning of the refrigerator.

She leaves her hand where it is.

A little later, she turns on the light and goes to the bedroom.

There are still evenings when she checks the lock twice and leaves the television talking until morning. Other times, she remains in front of the window while the garden slowly disappears.

Meanwhile, the violet loses one petal after another. Alison continues to visit it, picks up a few dry leaves, clears the fallen twigs from the moss. She no longer tries to move it.

One morning, she goes out before dawn and reaches the low wall on the quayside overlooking the horizon.

The water is dark, almost indistinguishable from the sky. A thin grey line separates the sea from the clouds. Alison remains watching it as the wind tousles her hair.

Little by little, the darkness takes on the colour of iron, then that of silver. The first clouds emerge from the darkness. A seagull crosses the sky without a cry.

When the sun appears, Alison is still sitting on the low wall.

On her way back, she buys some warm bread. She carries it under her arm, letting its warmth seep through her coat.

As she enters the house, she passes the room where she paints.

She stops.

The canvases of the violet are still leaning against the walls. Some show a pale flower, almost white. In others, the colour is lost among the stones. Alison takes a clean canvas and places it on the easel.

Then the day passes.

When the sun disappears behind the wall, she turns on a small lamp beside the window.

On the palette, she prepares a deep blue, mixes it with a touch of red and spreads it across the canvas. She adds the black of the wet stones, the dark green of the moss, the shadows of the branches against the wall.

She paints slowly, returning to the colours several times.

The violet appears almost last.

Alison prepares the violet colour and searches for the fold of a petal, the curve of the stem, the small shadow one leaf casts upon another.

The colour is dark.

She steps back from the easel. The flower seems to disappear among the stones.

She returns to the palette.

Beside the blue and red is a small amount of white. Alison brings the brush towards it, then draws it back. She wipes the bristles on the rag and picks up the violet again.

She lays one last brushstroke along the edge of a petal.

She steps back again.

The violet is there, between the stones. Some petals are barely distinguishable, others are lost in the moss. The light from the lamp brushes the canvas and leaves the flower in half-shadow.

Alison puts down the brush.

Outside, the garden is wrapped in darkness.

She turns off the lamp.

She remains in front of the open window. The cold air brushes her face. Somewhere beyond the wall, a branch continues to sway in the wind.

She searches with her eyes for the spot where the violet grows.

She cannot see it.

She turns towards the easel. The painting, too, is immersed in darkness. She could turn on the lamp, restore colour to the petals, let the light put everything back in its place.

She reaches a hand towards the switch.

Then draws it back.

She returns to the window and lets her eyes grow accustomed to the night. Little by little, she recognises the wall, the stones, the branches of the trees. The violet remains hidden.

Alison smiles faintly.

She does not close the window. She continues to look at the garden, even where her eyes cannot reach.
Behind her, in the darkness of the room, the painting retains its colours.
The violet is there, with her.